

1.3 History

1.3.1 Richard Stallman

The 1960s were a time when computers were too expensive to be afforded by individuals, and computer users had to be programmers. In those days, computer manufacturers bundled along the code for the operating system because this allowed users to solve most of the problems that arose due to the lacunae in the OS, thus saving the manufacturer's the bother.



It was normal for users to modify code to extend the capabilities of the OS, like in response to newer situations or requirements. And such modifications were passed on to other users who were in similar situations. The concept of open source did not originate then because it was a given, and sharing and distributing code was natural.

By the 1970s, OS manufacturers had started de-bundling the code from the software. Moreover, users were subject to conditions that prevented the sharing of the program. Programmers themselves were subject to non-disclosure agreements so that they would not reveal the source code publicly.

Richard Stallman, then working at the AI lab at MIT, confronted a peculiar situation (which is common now). A printer that was given to the MIT lab by Xerox frequently jammed. He intended to modify the printer driver so that rather than continue to accept print jobs, it would send a message to the connected computer that it had jammed. Xerox refused to provide the driver's source code. A person who had worked at Xerox creating the driver refused to reveal the source code since he had signed a non-disclosure agreement.

In many ways, the incident with the printer and the driver can be seen as the starting point of the OSS movement.